SMOKED CHEDDAR



THE BASICS

MAKE:	Hard
SUB MAKE:	Cheeses which acidify in the vat
POST-MAKE:	Flavoured or Smoked, Wrapped, Rolled or Processed
SUB POST-MAKE:	Smoked, Artificial (plastic coating, wax coat, matured in vacuum pack)
TYPICAL AGE PROFILE:	Three to 12 months
APPROXIMATE WEIGHT(S):	Various
GEOGRAPHICAL ORIGIN:	UK, but the name 'Cheddar' is not protected so the cheese is made and smoked in many countries throughout the world
PROTECTED STATUS:	N/A
SPECIES OF MILKING ANIMAL:	Cow
RAW/PASTEURISED MILK:	Examples of both depending on cheesemaker
VEGETARIAN/ANIMAL RENNET:	Examples of both depending on cheesemaker
COMMONLY ENCOUNTERED VARIATIONS:	N/A

THE STORY

Smoking has been used for millennia as a way of preserving and flavouring food, although smoked cheddar is a relatively recent development. Both block and cloth-bound versions can be smoked, with producers using different techniques. Some add smoke flavouring to the curd, others cold smoke the cheese over wood chippings, such as oak or maple, for several hours, while a combination of both techniques can also be employed.

The production steps are otherwise the same as for other types of cheddar, following the hard cheese process. The curds are cut, stirred and scalded to temperatures around 38-42°C to remove moisture. The whey is drained and the piles of curd are cut into blocks which are turned and stacked (cheddared) to drain more whey from the curds as they acidify. Once the target acidity is reached, the curds are milled and salted before moulding and pressing. The cheese is often cut into wedges and slices to help the flavour better penetrate during the cold smoking process.

THE CHARACTER

Smoked cheddar typically has a yellowy brown exterior from the smoking process with the level of smoke flavour dependant on how it was smoked and the cheese itself. The best versions have gentle smoky notes that are integrated with the flavours of the cheese itself.

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PERFECT PARTNERS:

A tricky cheese to match with wine. Try the floral spice of an Alsatian Gewurztraminer. Traditional British beers, such as bitter and golden ale are a safer bet.

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